

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> Pause -> Clarify -> Name -> Check -> Respond. -> **Cue:** notice the objection without treating it as a threat. -> **Pause:** resist the reflex to explain or rebut. -> **Clarify:** ask one short neutral question about the real concern. -> **Name:** reflect the concern in their words — "So the main issue is timeline risk." -> **Check, then respond:** confirm you have it right, then answer the actual concern or accept the boundary.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When resistance appears, ask one short neutral question — "What part of that is the main concern?" — then pause and listen before you respond.

BEST FOR

- Vague pushback like "I'm not sure" or "That won't work"
- "Too risky", "I don't like it", or "We tried that"
- "I need to think about it" and other stalls
- Objections that could be about several different things
- Decisions with real trade-offs
- Feedback conversations and change proposals
- Requests, negotiations, and repair conversations

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short one-liners

- "What part of that is the main concern?"
- "What's the main worry here?"
- "What's the sticking point?"
- "Which bit feels off?"
- "What's the real hesitation?"
- "What would need to change?"
- "Say more about what's not sitting right?"
- "What's the one thing that's stopping you?"

Soft and warm · Fragile or sensitive moments

- "Help me understand what feels off about it."
- "I want to get this right — what's the concern underneath it?"
- "No rush. What's making you hesitate?"
- "What matters most to you here?"
- "Fair enough. What would you need to feel okay about it?"
- "I'd rather understand than guess. What's the worry?"
- "What am I not seeing yet?"

Work and decisions · Meetings, proposals, decisions

- "Is your concern mainly about risk, timing, cost, or something else?"
- "Before I respond, is the blocker the plan itself or the deadline?"
- "Is this a scope worry, a resourcing worry, or confidence in delivery?"
- "When you say it feels risky, is that the timeline, the budget, or delivery?"
- "Is the hesitation about the change itself, or how the rollout will land?"

- "When you say this isn't workable, is the blocker scope, timing, or resourcing?"
- "Is the obstacle the number, the risk attached to it, or the terms?"

Two-option questions · Narrow it to a choice

- "Is the concern the risk itself, or the confidence that we can manage it?"
- "When you say it won't work, do you mean it can't, or not by Friday?"
- "Is it the idea you're unsure about, or the timing?"
- "Is this more about trust, or about workload?"
- "Do you mean it's wrong, or that it's not the right moment?"
- "Is that a not-yet, or a not-at-all?"
- "Is the issue the decision, or how it gets rolled out?"

Complaints and repair · When you missed or over-reached

- "Is the frustrating part the outcome, the delay, or how it was communicated?"
- "Is the main issue the original problem, or how we handled it after?"
- "I may have answered the wrong thing — what was the concern you wanted me to hear?"
- "I jumped ahead. Before options, what's the core concern?"
- "Let me make that simpler: is the concern more about timing, or trust?"
- "I'm not trying to talk you out of it — I'm trying to understand what matters."
- "No need to justify it. I just want to understand, not argue."

Boundary and high-pressure · Possible no, high stakes

- "You don't have to justify the no. If it's useful, I'd like to understand which concern matters most."
- "Let me slow down. What's the non-negotiable issue here?"
- "I'll respect your no. If you want to say, is there a specific concern you'd want me to understand?"
- "Before I try to answer, can I separate the concerns — is it evidence, risk, trust, or the precedent it sets?"
- "When you say this doesn't feel right, is it about trust, timing, or feeling pressured?"
- "This matters, so I'd rather get it right than get it fast. What's the real objection?"
- "If this is a firm no, tell me and I'll stop. If not, what's the concern?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Why not?" This sounds like a challenge and makes the person defend themselves.
Better: "What is your hesitation?" This opens the door, but can still sound slightly evaluative.
Best: "What part of that is the main concern?" This focuses on the issue rather than the person.
- Weak: "That's not really a problem." This dismisses the objection outright.
Better: "I think I can solve that." This may help, but it rushes past the concern.
Best: "Is the concern the risk itself, or the confidence that we can manage it?" This separates concern types before solving.
- Weak: "You're overthinking it." This attacks the person.
Better: "I can see why you'd ask." This validates, but doesn't clarify anything.
Best: "Fair question. What would you need to know before this felt safe enough to consider?" This clarifies their decision criteria.
- Weak: "But the data says it works." This buries the objection under proof.
Better: "What data would help?" This offers evidence, but may still miss the point.
Best: "Is your concern the evidence, the rollout risk, or trust in the source?" This diagnoses before proving.

DECISION TREE

If They gave a clear, final no or boundary

Respect it. Don't clarify unless they invite you.
"Understood. I'll respect that."

If The objection is vague, compressed, or ambiguous

Ask one neutral clarifying question about the concern.
"What part of that is the main concern?"

If They named a specific concern

Reflect it back and check before you respond.

"So the main concern is the timeline, not the plan?"

If The concern comes from missing information

Answer that specific gap, headline first.

"Here's the part you didn't have yet..."

If The concern is about trust, fairness, or past harm

Slow down; validate or repair before problem-solving.

"That makes sense given what happened last time."

If Your question landed badly

Recover and give them room.

"No need to justify it — I'm trying to understand, not argue."

SCENARIOS

Work proposal called risky

Split the vague risk into concrete categories before defending the plan. — "When you say the plan feels risky, is that the timeline, the budget, or confidence in delivery?"

Customer complaint

Separate the original problem from how it was handled. — "Is the main issue the original problem, the delay, or how the update was handled?"

Feedback pushback

Find whether they dispute the content or the fairness. — "When you push back on that, is the concern accuracy, fairness, or what happens next?"

Boundary conversation

Respect the no first, then offer an optional door to the concern. — "I'll respect your no. If you want to say, is there a specific concern you'd want me to understand?"

Negotiation stall

Locate whether the block is the number, the risk, or the terms. — "Is the obstacle the number itself, the risk attached to it, or the terms around it?"

Team change resisted

Separate the change itself from how it gets rolled out. — "Is the hesitation about the change itself, or about how people will experience the rollout?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They have already given a clear, final no or boundary
- The moment calls for an apology, not more questions
- Safety, privacy, or immediate practical help matters more
- Silence would serve them better than another question
- You are using questions to stall, win, or keep the pressure on
- You want them to justify themselves rather than be understood

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Sort the concern

Take ten vague objections you've heard recently and, for each, list which concern categories it could belong to: risk, cost, timing, trust, fairness, workload, evidence, identity, control, or values.

Day 2 — One question each

For each of those ten objections, write a single clarifying question. Delete any second question unless the first answer would clearly invite it.

Day 3 — Tone calibration

Say "What part of that is the main concern?" out loud in three tones — defensive, clinical, and warm. Record yourself if you can. Keep only the warm version.

Day 4 — Reflect before answering

In a low-stakes conversation, practise saying "So the concern is..." and checking it back before you offer any response.

Day 5 — Boundary stop

Rehearse accepting a clear no with "Understood. I'll respect that." Practise until stopping feels as natural as continuing.

Day 6 — Two-option questions

Turn five of your open clarifiers into two-option questions ("Is it the risk, or the confidence we can manage it?") and notice which ones lower the effort of answering.

Day 7 — Live run

In one real conversation where someone pushes back, make exactly one clarifying move, reflect the concern back, then respond to the actual concern — and notice whether the exchange got more accurate.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I clarify the objection before answering it?
- Did my question sound curious rather than challenging?
- Did I ask about the concern, not the person?
- Did I reflect the actual concern back in their words?
- Did I stop after one question when they needed space?
- Did I protect autonomy, dignity, and safety — and respect a clear no?